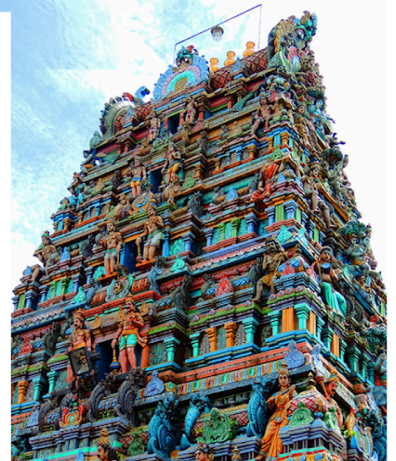


General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Schools of Philosophy



SCHOOLS OF PHILOSOPHY



Concepts of Indian Philosophy

- Indian philosophy encompasses several philosophical traditions that originated in the Indian subcontinent, including **Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain** philosophy.
- They include both **orthodox (Astika) systems**, such as the **Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Samkhya, Yoga, Purva-Mimamsa (or Mimamsa), and Vedanta** schools of thought, and **unorthodox (nastika) systems**, such as **Buddhism and Jainism**.
- The book *Sarva Darsana Samgraha*, written by **Sri Madhavacariya**, contains the quintessence of a few systems of thought that evolved in ancient India.
- Indian philosophical thoughts deal with various philosophical aspects, significant among which are the **nature of the world (cosmology)**, the **nature of reality (metaphysics)**, **logic**, the **nature of knowledge (epistemology)**, **ethics**, and the **philosophy of religion**.

Indian Philosophy

Indian philosophy is called '**Darsana**', meaning "intuitive vision." Darsana consists of wisdom about reality and the inner and outer secrets of human life. It forms the basis of inquiry about **metaphysical doctrines, logical truths, ethical codes, and religious practices**.

- **Punarjanam (Rebirth):**

Individuals reincarnate repeatedly, passing through many cycles of births and deaths, evolving through different life forms. The cycle of rebirth ends upon attaining **Moksha (liberation)**.

- **Rina (Debt):**

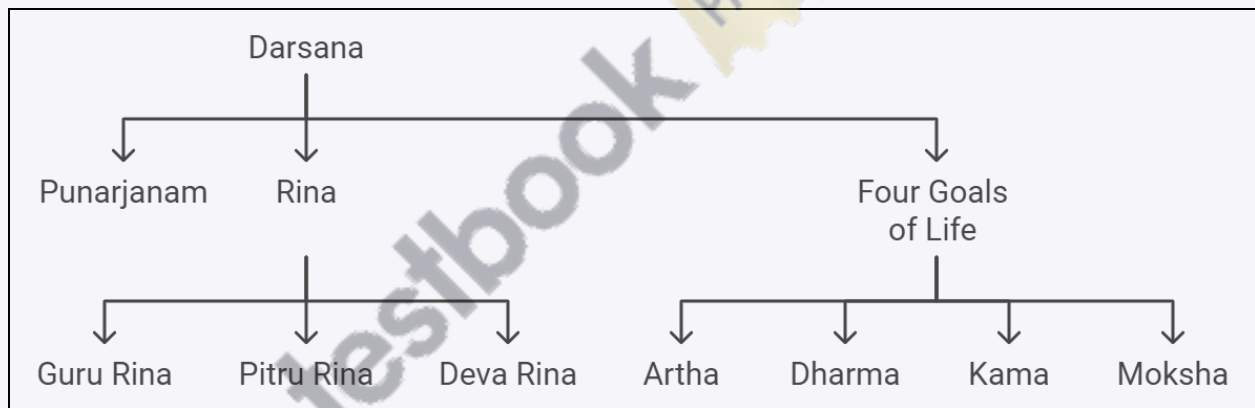
Rina refers to an individual's obligation to their duties to ensure continuity in tradition.

Three major types of debt:

- **Guru Rina** – Debt towards teachers.
- **Pitru Rina** – Debt towards ancestors.
- **Deva Rina** – Debt towards gods.

- **Four Goals of Human Life:**

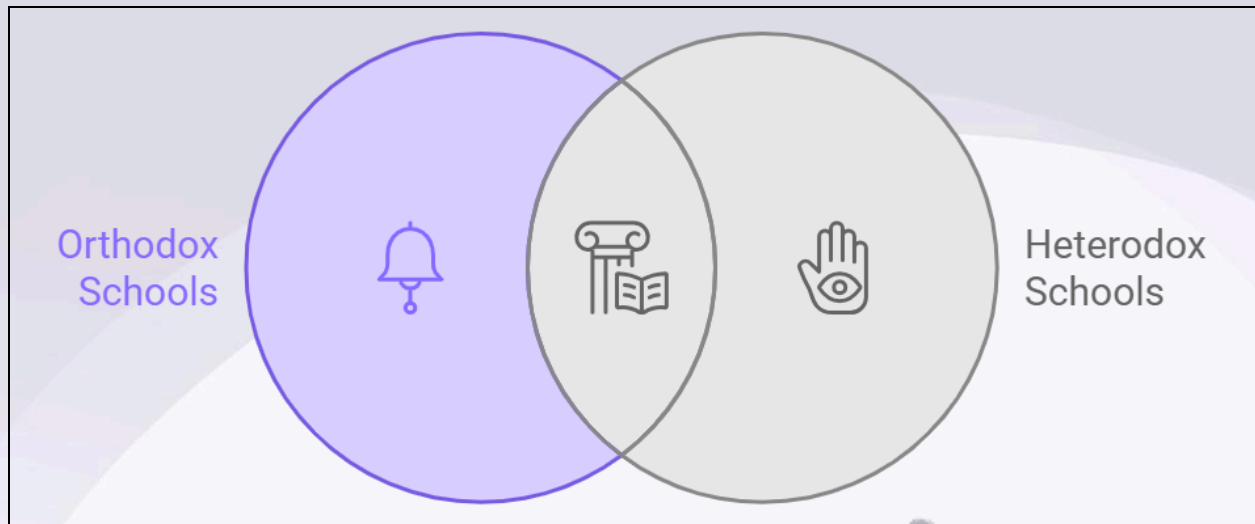
- **Artha:** Economic wealth.
- **Dharma:** Moral life.
- **Kama:** Emotional fulfillment and pleasure.
- **Moksha:** Liberation from the cycle of rebirth.



Types of Schools in Indian Philosophy

The philosophical systems of India are classified as **Orthodox (Astika)** and **Heterodox (Nastika)** schools based on their **acceptance or rejection of the Vedic authority**.

- **Orthodox Schools (Astika):** Accept the **authority of the Vedas**.
 - **Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Samkhya, Yoga, Mimamsa, and Vedanta.**
- **Heterodox Schools (Nastika):** Reject the Vedic authority.
 - **Buddhism, Jainism, and Charvaka.**



Orthodox Schools of Indian Philosophy

These schools believe the **Vedas are the supreme authority** for spiritual knowledge and do not question their authenticity. They developed during the **medieval period of Brahmanic-Sanskritic scholasticism**. The six major sub-schools are collectively known as **Shada Darshana**:

Philosophical Schools Converging on Knowledge



1. Samkhya School

- **Founder: Kapil Mani**
- **Core Philosophy:** Dualistic philosophy that explains the universe as arising from the interaction of two realities:
 - **Purusha (Self or Consciousness)** – Pure consciousness or soul.
 - **Prakriti (Matter or Nature)** – Creative force or the material world.
- **Theory of Causation:**
 - **Satkarya-vada:** The effect pre-exists in the cause. The transformation of cause leads to the manifestation of the effect.
- **Knowledge Types (Pramana):**
 - **Pratyaksha:** Perception
 - **Anumana:** Inference
 - **Shabda:** Testimony (Hearing)
- **Key Text:** *Samkhya Sutra*
- **Other Features:**
 - It is the **oldest school of Indian philosophy**.
 - Emphasizes **liberation (moksha)** through knowledge of the self.

2. Yoga School

- **Founder: Patanjali**
- **Core Philosophy:** Focuses on **attaining liberation (moksha)** through meditation, ethical discipline, and physical practices.
- **Key Text:** *Yoga Sutras of Patanjali*
- **Philosophy:** Yoga is seen as a **practical extension** of Samkhya philosophy. It teaches control over the body, mind, and senses.
- **Eight Limbs (Ashtanga Yoga):**
 - **Yama:** Ethical restraints (non-violence, truthfulness, etc.).
 - **Niyama:** Positive duties (cleanliness, contentment, etc.).
 - **Asana:** Steady physical postures.
 - **Pranayama:** Breath control.
 - **Pratyahara:** Withdrawal of senses from objects.
 - **Dharana:** Concentration on a single object.
 - **Dhyana:** Meditation.

- **Samadhi:** Complete absorption in the object of meditation.
- **Concept of God:** Yoga acknowledges **Ishvara (God)** as a teacher and guide in the pursuit of liberation.

3. Nyaya School

- **Founder:** Akshapad Gautam
- **Core Philosophy:** Focuses on **logic and reasoning** to attain knowledge and liberation.
- **Key Text:** *Nyaya Sutras*
- **Theory of Knowledge:**
 - Knowledge arises from four valid sources:
 - **Pratyaksha (Perception)**
 - **Anumana (Inference)**
 - **Upamana (Comparison)**
 - **Shabda (Testimony)**
- **Concept of God:**
 - God is regarded as the **creator, sustainer, and destroyer** of the universe.
 - The universe is composed of **eternal atoms**, and God guides these atoms to form the physical world.

4. Vaisheshika School

- **Founder:** Kanada
- **Core Philosophy:** Focuses on **metaphysics and ontology**.
 - The universe is composed of **atoms** (anu), which are eternal and indestructible.
- **Theory of Elements:**
 - The universe is formed by five main elements called **Dravya**: fire, air, water, earth, and sky (ether).
- **Concept of God:**
 - Similar to Nyaya, it believes God guides the universe by **combining atoms** to form material objects.
- **Goal of Life:**
 - Liberation is attained through **knowledge of the self and reality**.

5. Mimamsa School (Purva Mimamsa)

- **Founder: Jamini**
- **Core Philosophy:** Focuses on **rituals** and **Vedic texts**. It emphasizes the **performance of duties** (karma) to achieve spiritual liberation.
- **Key Text:** *Mimamsa Sutras* by Jamini
- **Ritualism:**
 - Mimamsa developed the **ritualistic aspect** of the Vedas and believed that performing rituals correctly leads to **material prosperity and moksha**.
- **Commentators:**
 - **Kumarila Bhatta** and **Prabhakara Misra** are two prominent scholars of Mimamsa.
- **Knowledge Types:**
 - Mimamsa accepts five sources of valid knowledge:
 - **Anumana (Inference)**
 - **Upamana (Comparison)**
 - **Shabda (Testimony)**
 - **Arthapatti (Postulation)**
 - **Anupalabdhi (Non-perception)**

6. Vedanta School

- **Founder: Vyasa**
- **Core Philosophy:** The **ultimate reality is Brahman**, and liberation is achieved through **knowledge of the self (Atman)**.
- **Key Text:** *Brahma Sutras* by Badrayana
- **Philosophical Focus:** Vedanta is concerned with the **nature of reality, the self, and God**.
- **Main Traditions of Vedanta:**
 - **Advaita Vedanta (Non-dualism):**
 - **Philosopher:** Adi Shankaracharya
 - **Philosophy:** The self (Atman) and Brahman are one.
 - **Vishishtadvaita (Qualified Non-dualism):**
 - **Philosopher:** Ramanuja
 - **Philosophy:** The self is distinct but dependent on Brahman.

- **Dvaita (Dualism):**
 - **Philosopher:** Madhvacharya
 - **Philosophy:** The self and God are entirely distinct.
- **Theory of Rebirth:**
 - Vedanta accepts **punarjanma (rebirth)** and believes that liberation (moksha) can be attained through **self-knowledge and devotion**.

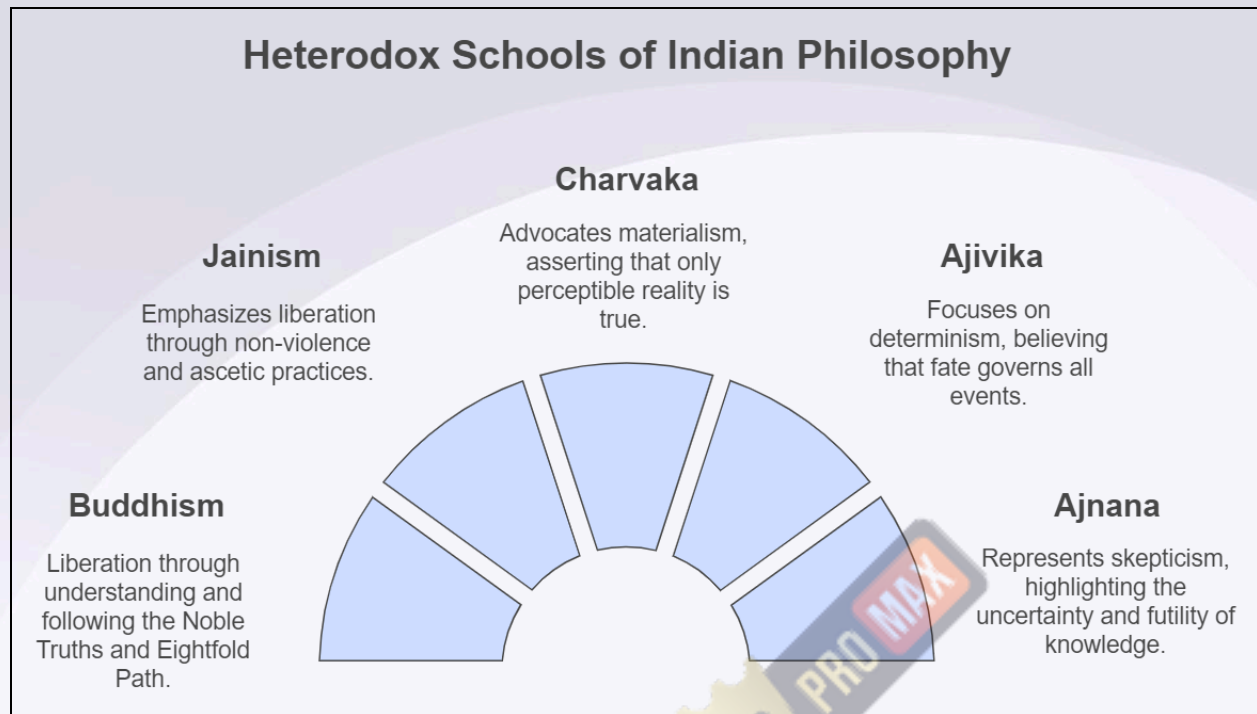
Summary of Orthodox Schools of Indian Philosophy

School	Founder	Core Philosophy
Samkhya	Kapil Mani	Dualism of Purusha and Prakriti .
Yoga	Patanjali	Meditation and physical discipline lead to liberation.
Nyaya	Akshapad Gautam	Logic and reasoning as a path to knowledge.
Vaisheshika	Kanada	Atomism and the role of God in the universe.
Mimamsa	Jamini	Focus on rituals and Vedic authority .
Vedanta	Vyasa	Brahman is the ultimate reality .

These **six orthodox schools of Indian philosophy** form the foundation of **Hindu philosophical thought**, each offering a distinct perspective on **the nature of reality, knowledge, and liberation**. The goal across these schools is to provide pathways to **moksha (liberation)** through **knowledge, discipline, rituals, or devotion**.

Heterodox Schools of Indian Philosophy

The **heterodox (Nastika) schools** of Indian philosophy are those that **reject the authority of the Vedas**. These schools challenge the ritualism, social hierarchy, and metaphysical doctrines propagated by the Vedic tradition. **Buddhism, Jainism, Charvaka, Ajivika, and Ajnana** are the major heterodox philosophies. These schools are concerned with **practical ethics, individual liberation, and social equality**.



1. Buddhist Philosophy

- **Founder: Gautama Buddha**
- **Core Philosophy:** Emphasizes the **Four Noble Truths** and **Eightfold Path** to end suffering (dukkha).
- **Four Noble Truths:**
 - **Dukkha:** Life is full of suffering.
 - **Samudaya:** Desire is the cause of suffering.
 - **Nirodha:** Ending desire ends suffering.
 - **Magga:** Following the Eightfold Path leads to liberation (Nirvana).
- **Eightfold Path:**
 - Right View, Right Intention, Right Speech, Right Action, Right Livelihood, Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, and Right Concentration.
- **Theory of No-Self (Anatta):** Rejects the concept of a permanent soul.
- **View on Karma:** Actions determine future rebirths.

2. Jain Philosophy

- **Founder: Mahavira** (the 24th Tirthankara)

- **Core Philosophy:** The goal is **liberation (Moksha)** through **non-violence (Ahimsa)**, **truth**, and **asceticism**.
- **Key Concepts:**
 1. **Anekantavada:** Reality has multiple perspectives.
 2. **Syadavada:** Every statement is valid from a particular viewpoint.
 3. **Karma Theory:** Karma binds the soul to the cycle of birth and death. Liberation is achieved by purifying the soul.
- **Two Major Sects:**
 1. **Digambara:** Practitioners do not wear clothes, emphasizing total renunciation.
 2. **Svetambara:** Practitioners wear white clothes, emphasizing practical asceticism.

3. Charvaka School (Lokayata Philosophy)

- **Founder:** Brihaspati
- **Core Philosophy: Materialism** – Only what is perceived through the senses is real.
- **Key Tenets:**
 - **Pratyaksha (Perception)** is the only valid source of knowledge.
 - Rejection of **karma, rebirth, afterlife**, and **soul**.
 - The universe is made up of **four elements**: Earth, Air, Fire, and Water.
 - **Hedonism:** Pursuit of pleasure and avoidance of pain is the goal of life.
- **View on God:** Charvaka's philosophy denies the existence of God or any metaphysical reality.

4. Ajivika Philosophy

- **Founder:** Goshala Maskariputra
- **Core Philosophy: Absolute determinism (Niyati)** – Everything in the universe is pre-determined by fate.
- **Key Concepts:**
 - **Niyati:** The course of life is fixed, and human effort cannot change it.
 - **Atman:** Belief in the existence of an individual soul that transmigrates.
 - **Denial of free will:** Human actions cannot alter the outcome pre-determined by fate.
- **Sources of Knowledge:**

- **Digha Nikaya, Samyutta Nikaya, and Suttrakritanga-sutra** describe Ajivika teachings.
- **Decline:** The school declined over time due to its rigid determinism and opposition from Buddhist and Jain philosophers.

5. Ajnana Philosophy

- **Founder: Sanjaya Belatthiputta**
- **Core Philosophy: Skepticism** – It is impossible to obtain certain knowledge about metaphysical realities.
- **Key Concepts:**
 - Knowledge of the absolute truth is either **impossible** or **useless**.
 - **Rejection of philosophical debates** as they do not lead to practical benefits.
 - Advocated **mental equanimity** and disengagement from intellectual arguments.
- **Mentions in Texts:**
 - Recorded in **Theravada Buddhism's Pali Canon** and **Suyagadanga (Jain text)**.

Summary of Heterodox Schools of Indian Philosophy

School	Founder	Core Philosophy
Buddhism	Gautama Buddha	Liberation through Noble Truths and Eightfold Path .
Jainism	Mahavira	Liberation through non-violence and asceticism .
Charvaka	Brihaspati	Materialism – Only what is perceptible is real.
Ajivika	Goshala Maskariputra	Determinism – Fate controls everything.
Ajnana	Sanjaya Belatthiputta	Skepticism – Knowledge is uncertain and useless.

Key Differences Between Orthodox and Heterodox Schools

- **Acceptance of the Vedas:** Orthodox schools accept the authority of the **Vedas**, while heterodox schools reject them.
- **Belief in God:** Some heterodox schools like **Buddhism** and **Charvaka** reject the concept of God.

- **Social Reform:** Heterodox schools oppose **ritualism** and **caste hierarchy**, promoting ethical behaviour and individual liberation.

